

Spending, Students, and Per-Pupil Costs

Andover, Hebron, Marlborough & RHAM · FY 2013 – FY 2023 · What ten years of federal school-finance data say about rising per-pupil costs

A personal report by Scott Sauyet · scott@sauyet.com · Not an official town document

Every dollar figure in this report comes from one source: the school district finance survey (F-33) collected annually by the U.S. Census Bureau and published jointly with the National Center for Education Statistics, using the same definitions for every district in every year. Spending is current expenditure for elementary and secondary programs on the NCES basis, which includes Connecticut's state-paid teacher retirement contributions, so levels here run higher than the state's NCEP figures and the two should never be compared directly. Enrollment is F-33 fall membership, the October count, which matches the state's PSIS-derived counts exactly. Inflation is CPI-U averaged over each July-to-June fiscal year. The most recent year published is FY 2023 (school year 2022-23). Figures for 2021-22 and 2022-23 were harmonized from Census files onto the NCES basis and verified to reconcile exactly, to the dollar, against the NCES series in the overlapping year. Town adjacency is computed from Census TIGER 2023 boundaries with mapped water removed, so towns count as neighbors only where they share dry ground. Group figures are enrollment-weighted: combined spending divided by combined students.

INTRODUCTION

Overview

When school budgets are debated in Andover, Hebron, and Marlborough, one number does most of the talking: cost per pupil. It is a genuinely useful number, and this report uses it throughout. But a ratio has two parts, and a per-pupil figure can rise because spending grew, because enrollment shrank, or both. Which one is doing the work matters enormously for what, if anything, a town should do about it.

This report separates the two. For each place examined, one chart shows four lines over the ten years from FY 2013 to FY 2023: per-pupil cost, total spending, enrollment, and inflation, all as cumulative change from the same starting year. Reading them together answers the question the per-pupil number alone cannot: are our schools getting more expensive, or are they serving fewer students?

The report starts with the three towns and their shared regional district taken as one system, then examines each of the four districts separately. It then widens the lens three times, to progressively larger contiguous blocks of surrounding towns, and closes with two reference groups: the 45 elementary-only districts that are Andover's structural peers, and the state as a whole.

METHODOLOGY

A Note on the Numbers

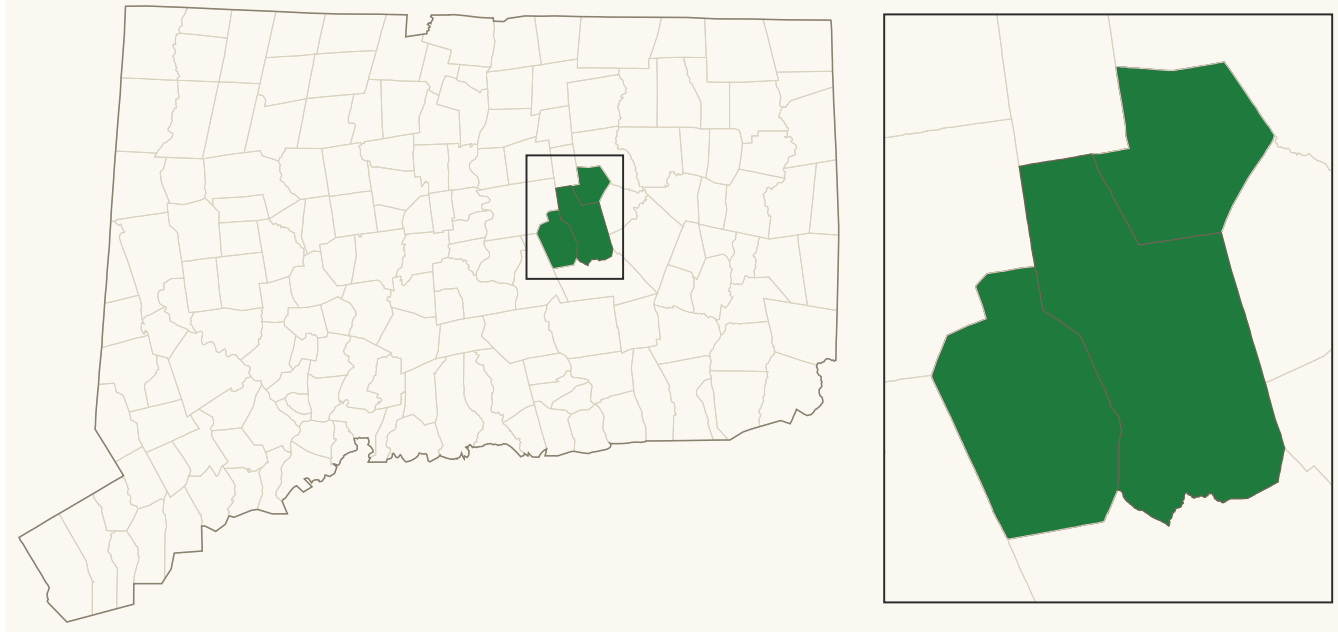
Three methodological points shape everything that follows. First, the spending basis includes costs that never appear in a local budget, chiefly the state's payments into the teacher retirement system on districts' behalf. This is applied identically to every district in every year, so trends and comparisons are sound, but the dollar levels are not the town appropriation and are not comparable to NCEP. Second, all group figures weight by enrollment: they are the combined spending of the group's districts divided by their combined students, so larger districts matter more, exactly as they do in the underlying totals. Third, regional school districts are separate entities from their member towns' local districts. A Hebron seventh grader is counted in RHAM's enrollment and nowhere else, so sums across a town-and-region group count every student and every dollar exactly once.

THE REGION

Part 1 — The Region as One System

Andover, Hebron, and Marlborough run three local elementary districts and share one regional district, RHAM, for grades 7 through 12. RHAM's territory is exactly the three towns, so the four districts together are the complete public school system of the region, and the natural place to start.

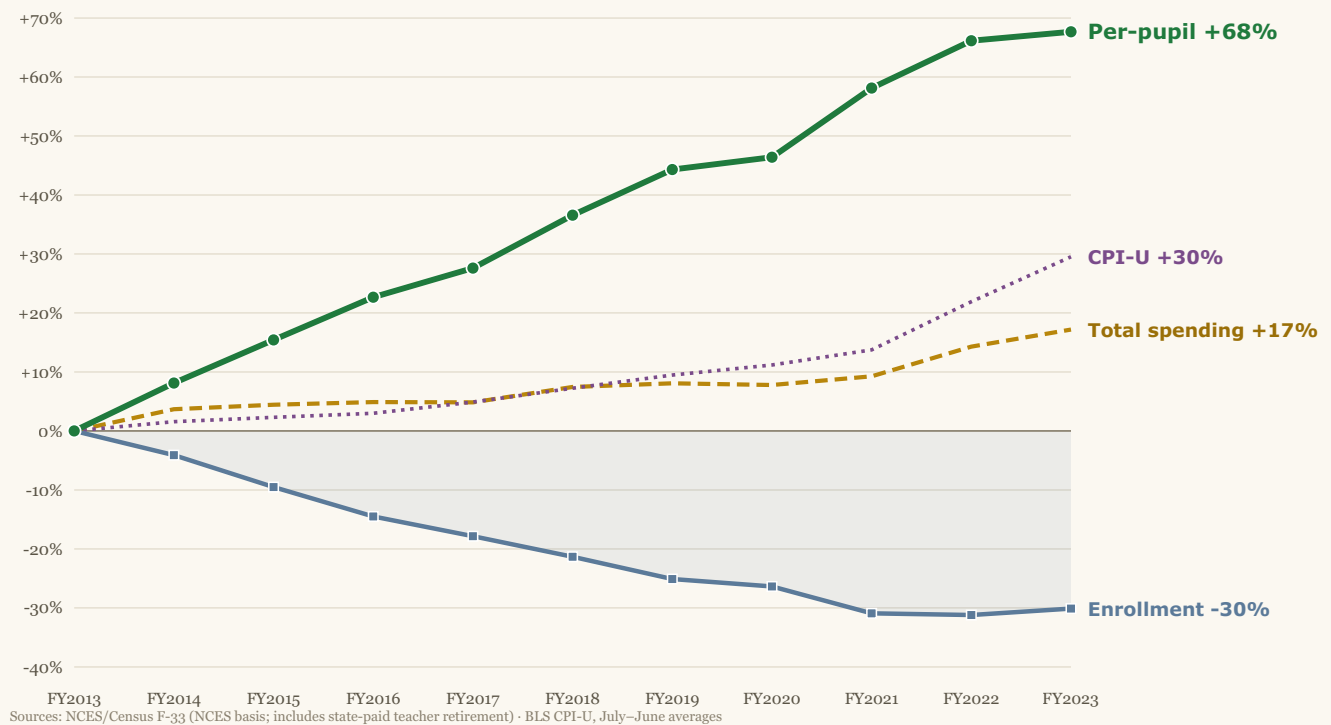
Andover + Hebron + Marlborough + RHAM



The combined picture over ten years is stark. Enrollment fell 30 percent, from 3,656 students to 2,555. Total spending rose 17 percent, which is well below the 29.5 percent rise in consumer prices over the same window: in real dollars, the region's residents paid meaningfully less for their schools in 2022-23 than they did in 2012-13. Per-pupil cost nonetheless rose 68 percent. That is the arithmetic of decline: a real-terms spending cut, divided by a much faster enrollment decline, produces a per-pupil number that looks like runaway growth.

Andover + Hebron + Marlborough + RHAM

Cumulative change since FY2013: per-pupil cost, total current spending, enrollment, and inflation



The chart makes the mechanism visible. The gold spending line runs below the purple inflation line for the entire decade. The blue enrollment line sinks steadily to 30 percent below its starting point. The green per-pupil line is simply the widening gap between gold and blue. Nothing in this picture shows a school system spending its way to higher costs; it shows a fixed-cost system absorbing the loss of nearly a third of its students.

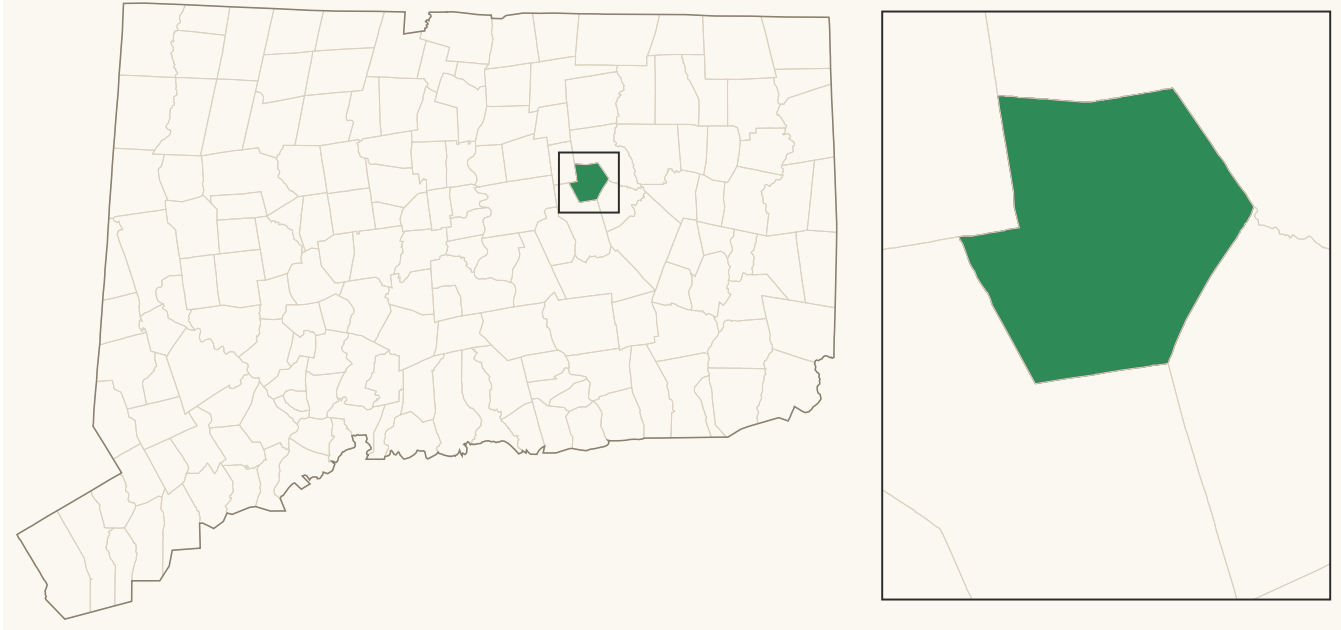
The four districts combined, FY 2013 – FY 2023 ✓ *Computed from NCES/Census F-33*

Fiscal year	School year	Students	Total current spending	Per pupil
2013	2012-13	3,656	\$52,806,000	\$14,444
2014	2013-14	3,506	\$54,750,000	\$15,616
2015	2014-15	3,308	\$55,148,000	\$16,671
2016	2015-16	3,126	\$55,389,000	\$17,719
2017	2016-17	3,004	\$55,362,000	\$18,429
2018	2017-18	2,876	\$56,738,000	\$19,728
2019	2018-19	2,738	\$57,073,000	\$20,845
2020	2019-20	2,692	\$56,924,000	\$21,146
2021	2020-21	2,526	\$57,693,000	\$22,840
2022	2021-22	2,515	\$60,355,000	\$23,998
2023	2022-23	2,555	\$61,877,000	\$24,218

Notes: NCES/Census F-33 school district finance data, NCES basis (current elementary-secondary expenditure; includes state on-behalf teacher retirement). Enrollment is F-33 fall membership (October counts). FY2022-23 harmonized from Census unit files; verified to reconcile exactly with the NCES series on the FY2021 overlap. Per pupil is combined spending divided by combined students, which weights each district by its enrollment.

Part 2 — Andover

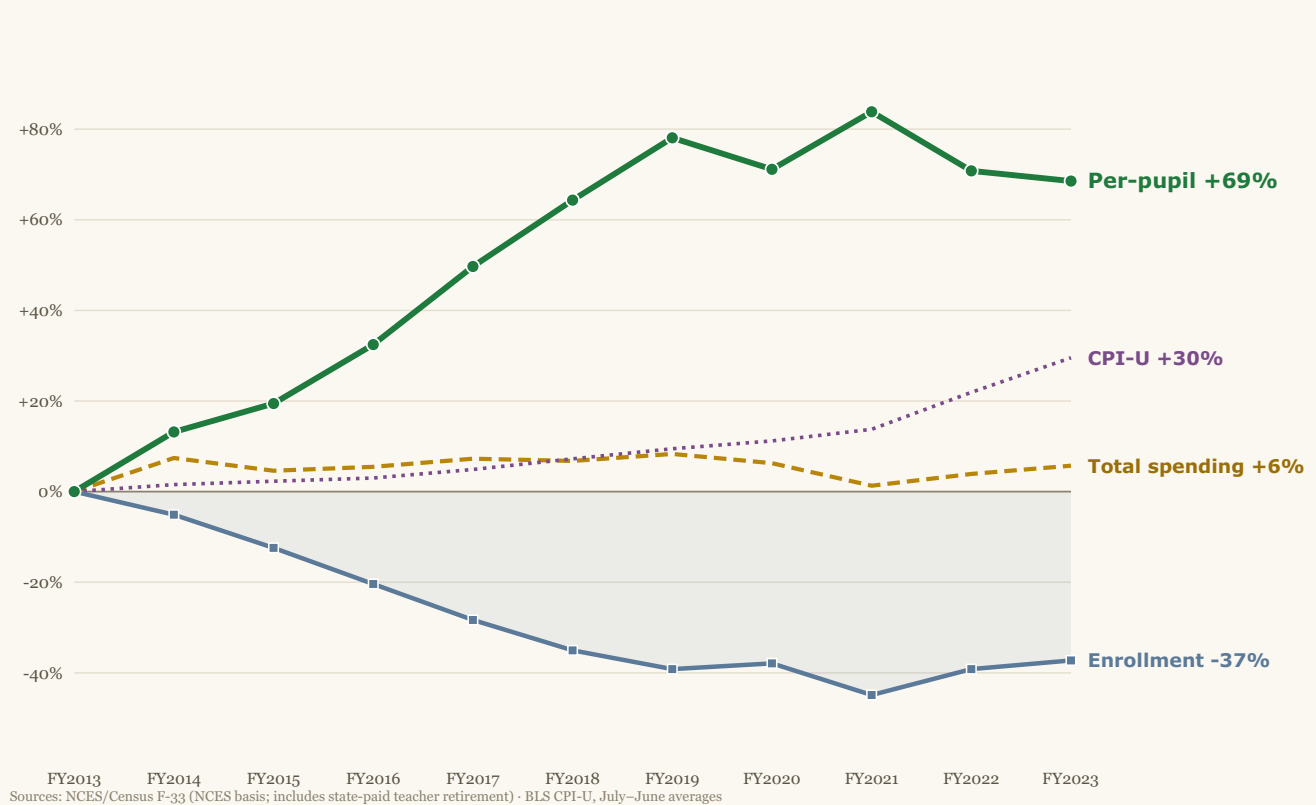
Andover (elementary district)



Andover Elementary School shows the sharpest contrast in this report between the per-pupil line and everything underneath it. Over ten years its total spending grew 5.7 percent, roughly half a percent per year, against 29.5 percent inflation. In real dollars, AES's budget shrank by about 18 percent. Enrollment fell 37 percent, from 314 students to 197. Per-pupil cost rose 68 percent, and every point of that rise above the spending line is the shrinking denominator, not new spending.

Andover (elementary district)

Cumulative change since FY2013: per-pupil cost, total current spending, enrollment, and inflation



A town whose school budget trailed inflation for a decade does not have a spending problem. It has a small-district arithmetic problem: classrooms, buildings, and core staff do not scale down smoothly with each departing student, so the cost of the remaining system is spread over fewer and fewer children.

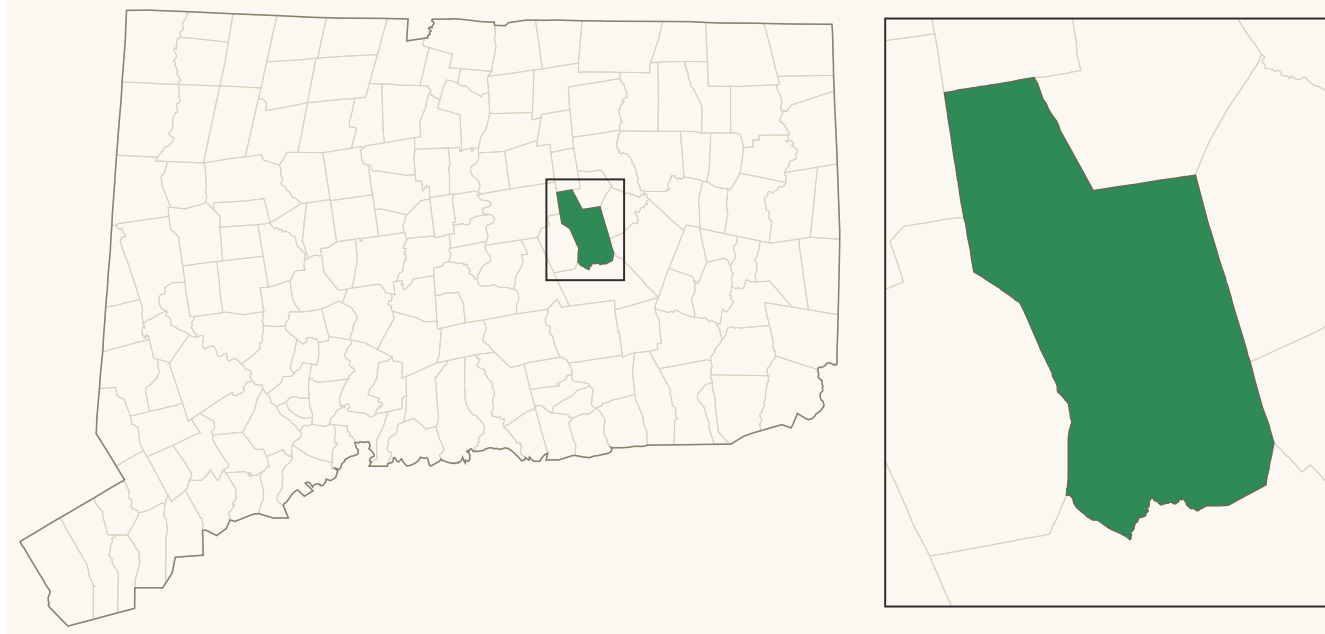
Andover, FY 2013 – FY 2023 ✓ *Computed from NCES/Census F-33*

Fiscal year	School year	Students	Total current spending	Per pupil
2013	2012-13	314	\$4,705,000	\$14,984
2014	2013-14	298	\$5,054,000	\$16,960
2015	2014-15	275	\$4,922,000	\$17,898
2016	2015-16	250	\$4,962,000	\$19,848
2017	2016-17	225	\$5,047,000	\$22,431
2018	2017-18	204	\$5,024,000	\$24,627
2019	2018-19	191	\$5,097,000	\$26,686
2020	2019-20	195	\$5,001,000	\$25,646
2021	2020-21	173	\$4,766,000	\$27,549
2022	2021-22	191	\$4,888,000	\$25,592
2023	2022-23	197	\$4,975,000	\$25,254

Notes: NCES/Census F-33 school district finance data, NCES basis (current elementary-secondary expenditure; includes state on-behalf teacher retirement). Enrollment is F-33 fall membership (October counts). FY2022-23 harmonized from Census unit files; verified to reconcile exactly with the NCES series on the FY2021 overlap. Per pupil is combined spending divided by combined students, which weights each district by its enrollment.

Part 3 — Hebron

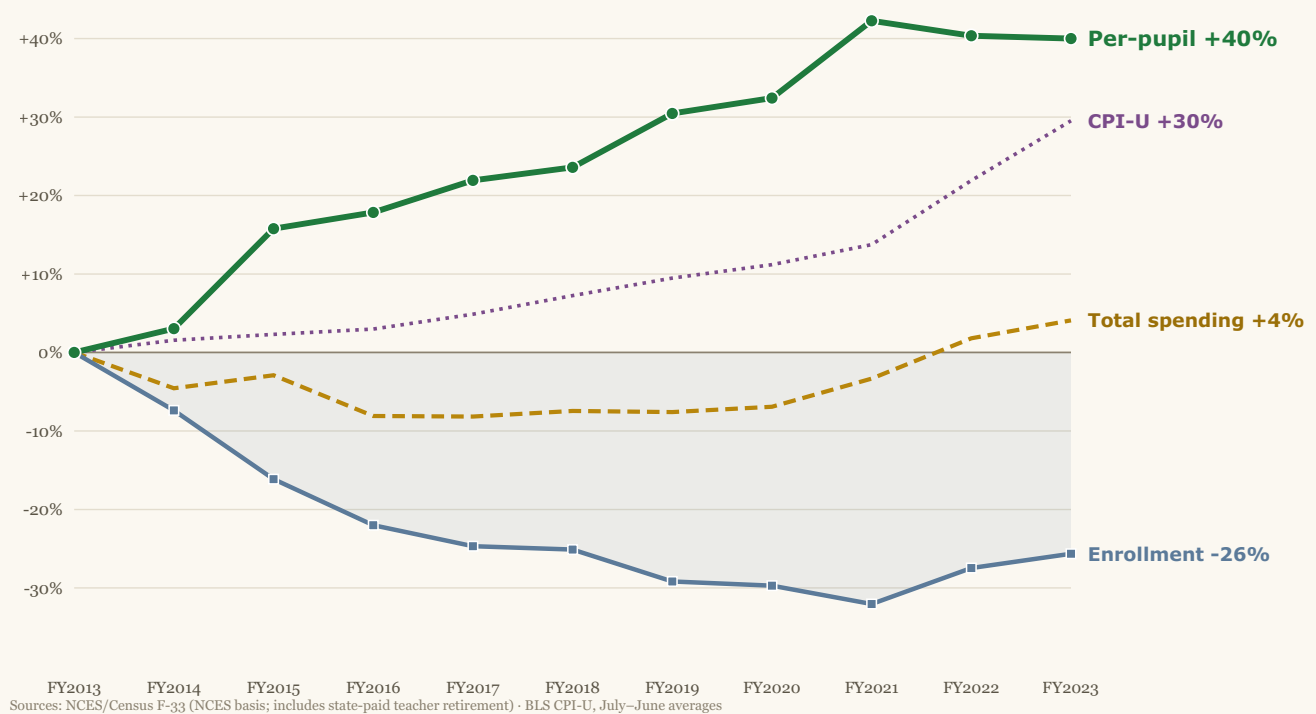
Hebron (elementary district)



Hebron's elementary district tells nearly the same story at three times the size. Total spending grew 4.1 percent over the decade, the most restrained spending line in the entire report, and far below inflation. Enrollment fell 26 percent, from 936 to 696. Per-pupil cost rose 40 percent, the smallest per-pupil increase of any group examined here, precisely because Hebron's enrollment decline, while severe, was the shallowest of the three towns.

Hebron (elementary district)

Cumulative change since FY2013: per-pupil cost, total current spending, enrollment, and inflation



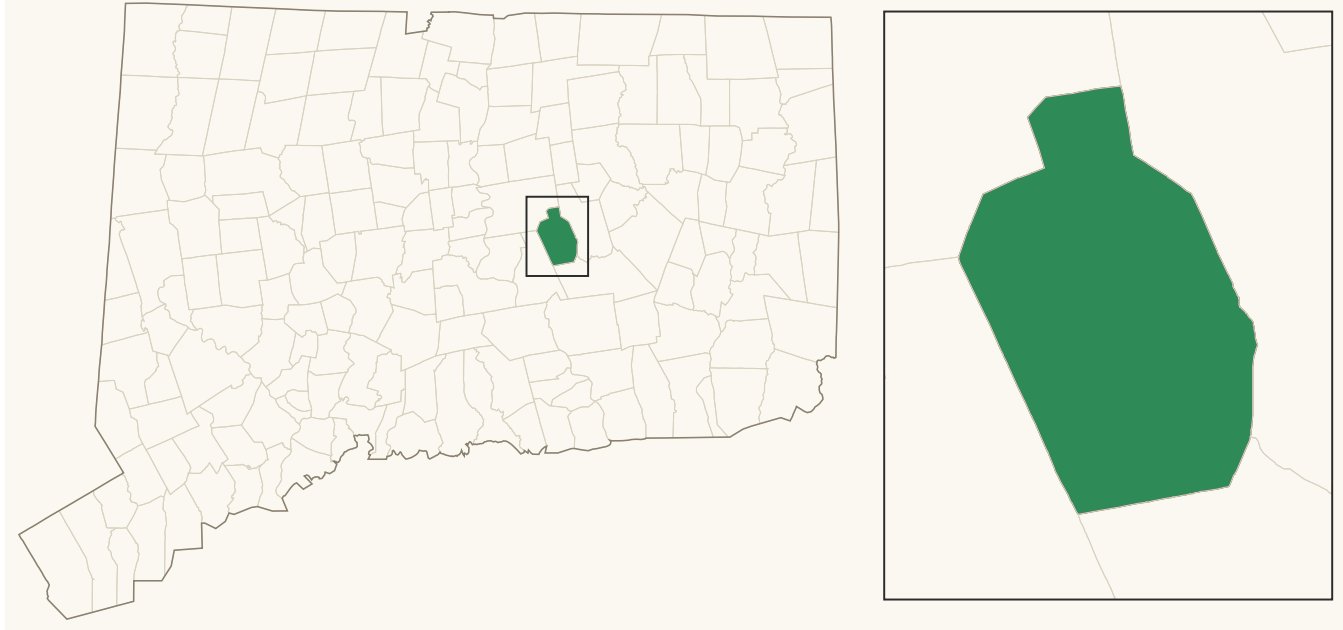
Hebron, FY 2013 – FY 2023 ✓ *Computed from NCES/Census F-33*

Fiscal year	School year	Students	Total current spending	Per pupil
2013	2012-13	936	\$14,717,000	\$15,723
2014	2013-14	867	\$14,047,000	\$16,202
2015	2014-15	785	\$14,291,000	\$18,205
2016	2015-16	730	\$13,527,000	\$18,530
2017	2016-17	705	\$13,515,000	\$19,170
2018	2017-18	701	\$13,622,000	\$19,432
2019	2018-19	663	\$13,600,000	\$20,513
2020	2019-20	658	\$13,700,000	\$20,821
2021	2020-21	636	\$14,227,000	\$22,369
2022	2021-22	679	\$14,984,000	\$22,068
2023	2022-23	696	\$15,320,000	\$22,011

Notes: NCES/Census F-33 school district finance data, NCES basis (current elementary-secondary expenditure; includes state on-behalf teacher retirement). Enrollment is F-33 fall membership (October counts). FY2022-23 harmonized from Census unit files; verified to reconcile exactly with the NCES series on the FY2021 overlap. Per pupil is combined spending divided by combined students, which weights each district by its enrollment.

Part 4 — Marlborough

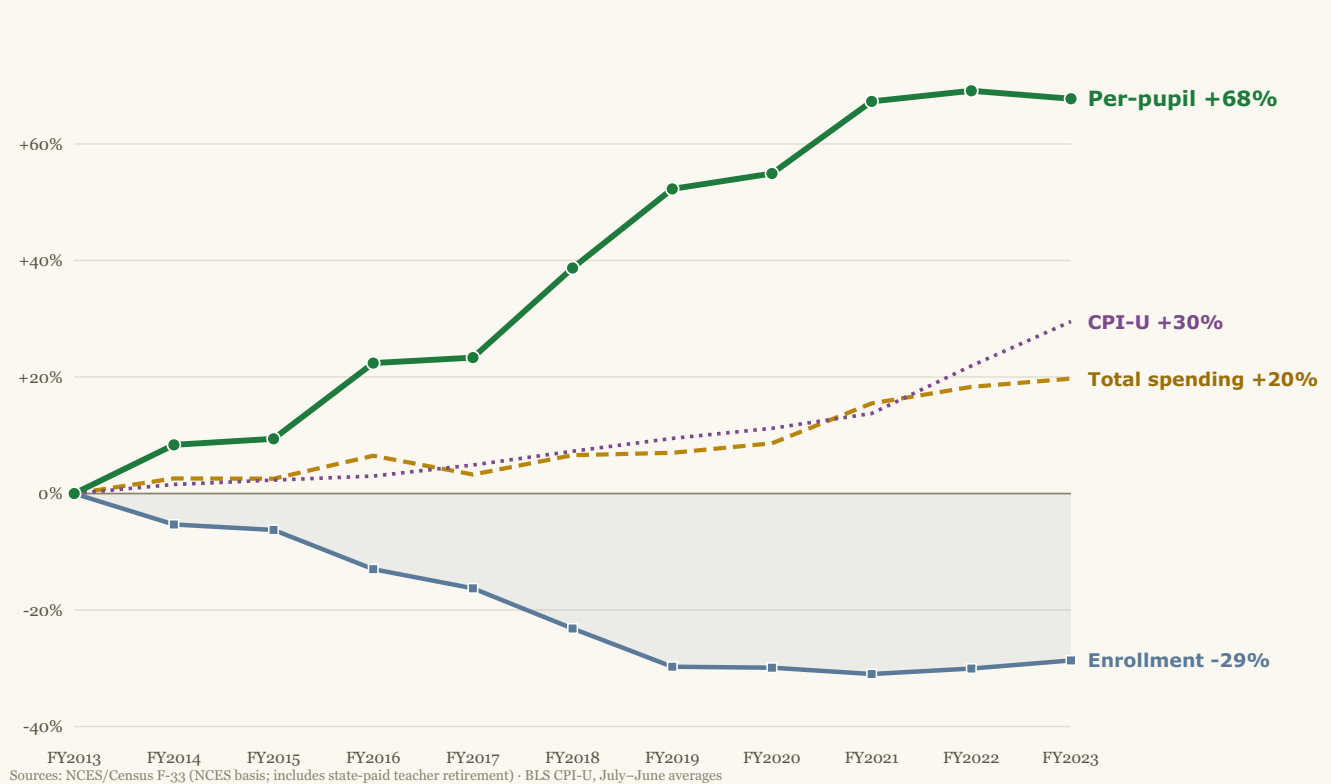
Marlborough (elementary district)



Marlborough sits between its neighbors: spending up 19.7 percent over ten years, still ten points below inflation, with enrollment down 29 percent, from 639 students to 456. Per-pupil cost rose 68 percent. As in Andover, the per-pupil line and the spending line diverge almost entirely because of the denominator.

Marlborough (elementary district)

Cumulative change since FY2013: per-pupil cost, total current spending, enrollment, and inflation



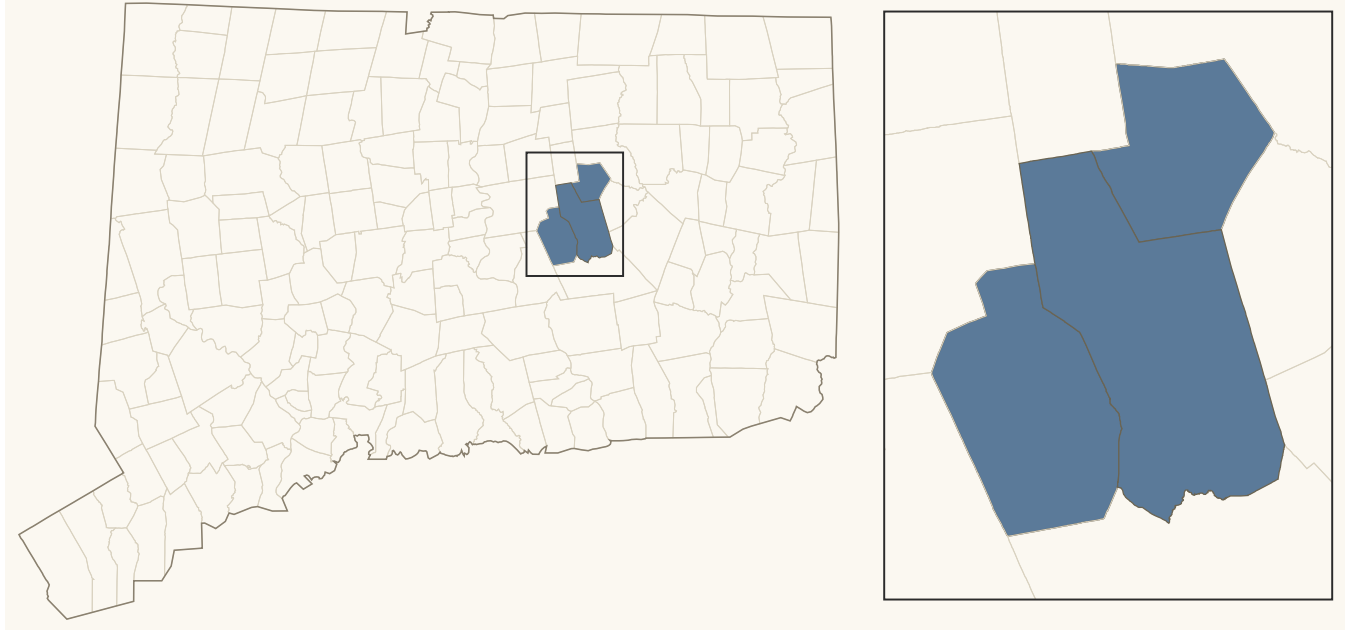
Marlborough, FY 2013 – FY 2023 ✓ *Computed from NCES/Census F-33*

Fiscal year	School year	Students	Total current spending	Per pupil
2013	2012-13	639	\$8,278,000	\$12,955
2014	2013-14	605	\$8,493,000	\$14,038
2015	2014-15	599	\$8,488,000	\$14,170
2016	2015-16	556	\$8,815,000	\$15,854
2017	2016-17	535	\$8,548,000	\$15,978
2018	2017-18	491	\$8,822,000	\$17,967
2019	2018-19	449	\$8,857,000	\$19,726
2020	2019-20	448	\$8,991,000	\$20,069
2021	2020-21	441	\$9,558,000	\$21,673
2022	2021-22	447	\$9,794,000	\$21,911
2023	2022-23	456	\$9,910,000	\$21,732

Notes: NCES/Census F-33 school district finance data, NCES basis (current elementary-secondary expenditure; includes state on-behalf teacher retirement). Enrollment is F-33 fall membership (October counts). FY2022-23 harmonized from Census unit files; verified to reconcile exactly with the NCES series on the FY2021 overlap. Per pupil is combined spending divided by combined students, which weights each district by its enrollment.

Part 5 — RHAM

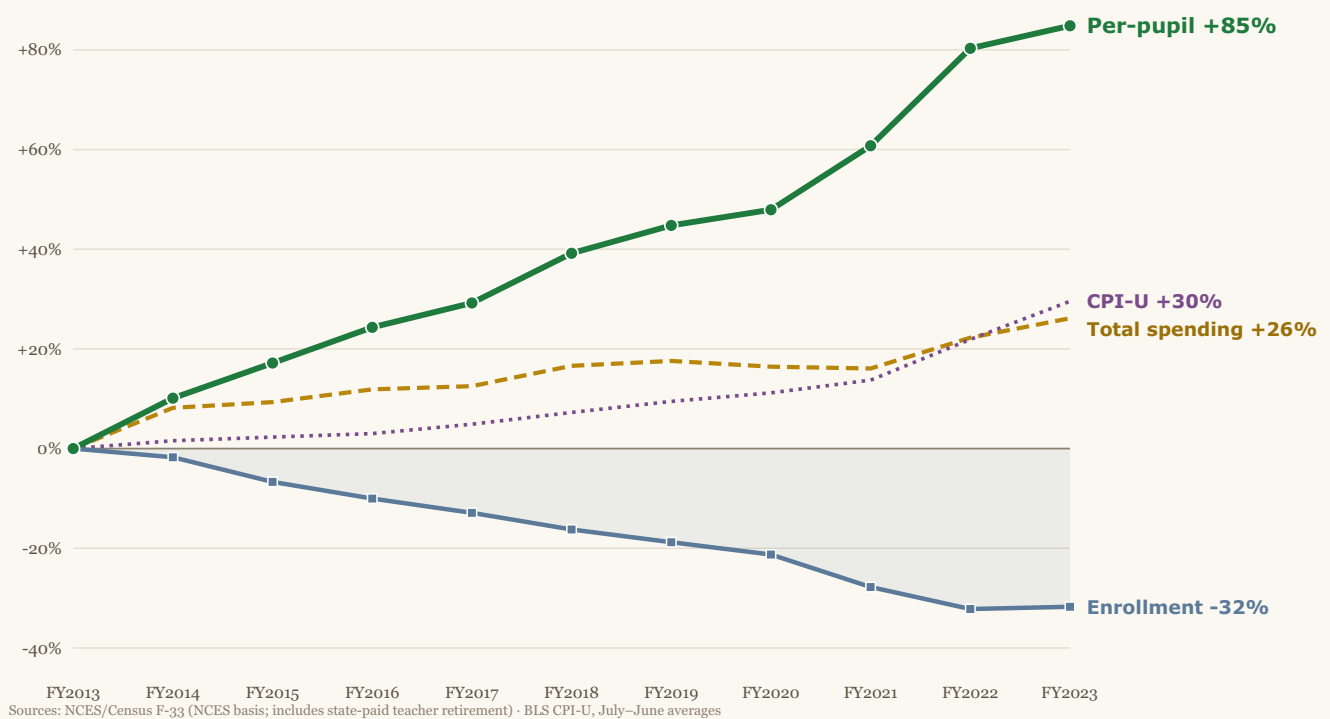
RHAM (Regional District 8)



RHAM, the three towns' shared district for grades 7 through 12, shows the region's largest numbers on both sides of the ratio. Spending grew 26 percent over the decade, modestly below inflation. Enrollment fell 32 percent, from 1,767 students to 1,206, as the smaller elementary cohorts of the 2010s reached the upper grades. Per-pupil cost rose 85 percent, the steepest line in this report, and the decomposition shows why: RHAM combines the region's deepest sustained enrollment slide with the fixed costs of operating a comprehensive middle and high school.

RHAM (Regional District 8)

Cumulative change since FY2013: per-pupil cost, total current spending, enrollment, and inflation



The elementary declines of the early 2010s arrive at RHAM's door six years later, which means RHAM's enrollment trough is partly still ahead even as the towns' elementary counts have begun to stabilize.

RHAM, FY 2013 – FY 2023 ✓ *Computed from NCES/Census F-33*

Fiscal year	School year	Students	Total current spending	Per pupil
2013	2012-13	1,767	\$25,106,000	\$14,208
2014	2013-14	1,736	\$27,156,000	\$15,643
2015	2014-15	1,649	\$27,447,000	\$16,645
2016	2015-16	1,590	\$28,085,000	\$17,664
2017	2016-17	1,539	\$28,252,000	\$18,357
2018	2017-18	1,480	\$29,270,000	\$19,777
2019	2018-19	1,435	\$29,519,000	\$20,571
2020	2019-20	1,391	\$29,232,000	\$21,015
2021	2020-21	1,276	\$29,142,000	\$22,839
2022	2021-22	1,198	\$30,689,000	\$25,617
2023	2022-23	1,206	\$31,672,000	\$26,262

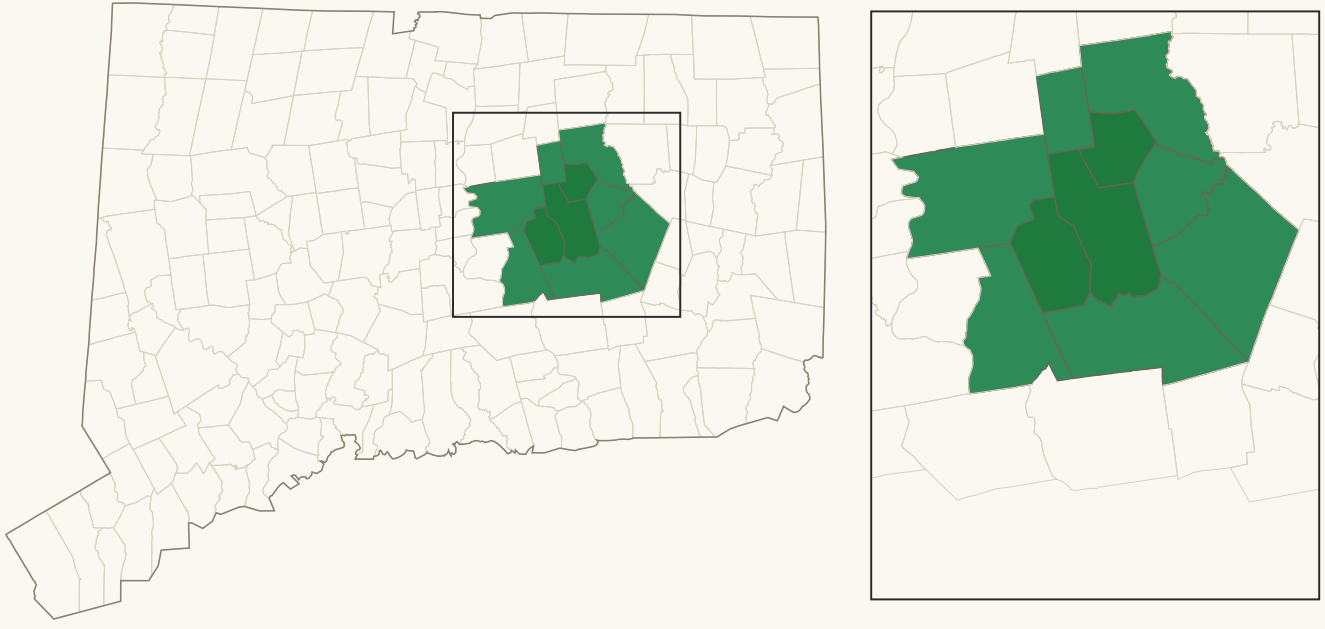
Notes: NCES/Census F-33 school district finance data, NCES basis (current elementary-secondary expenditure; includes state on-behalf teacher retirement). Enrollment is F-33 fall membership (October counts). FY2022-23 harmonized from Census unit files; verified to reconcile exactly with the NCES series on the FY2021 overlap. Per pupil is combined spending divided by combined students, which weights each district by its enrollment.

WIDER CONTEXT

Part 6 — Block 1: The Region and Its Neighbors

The remaining sections widen the lens for context. Block 1 adds every town sharing a land boundary with the core: Bolton, Colchester, Columbia, Coventry, East Hampton, Glastonbury, and Lebanon, eleven districts in all.

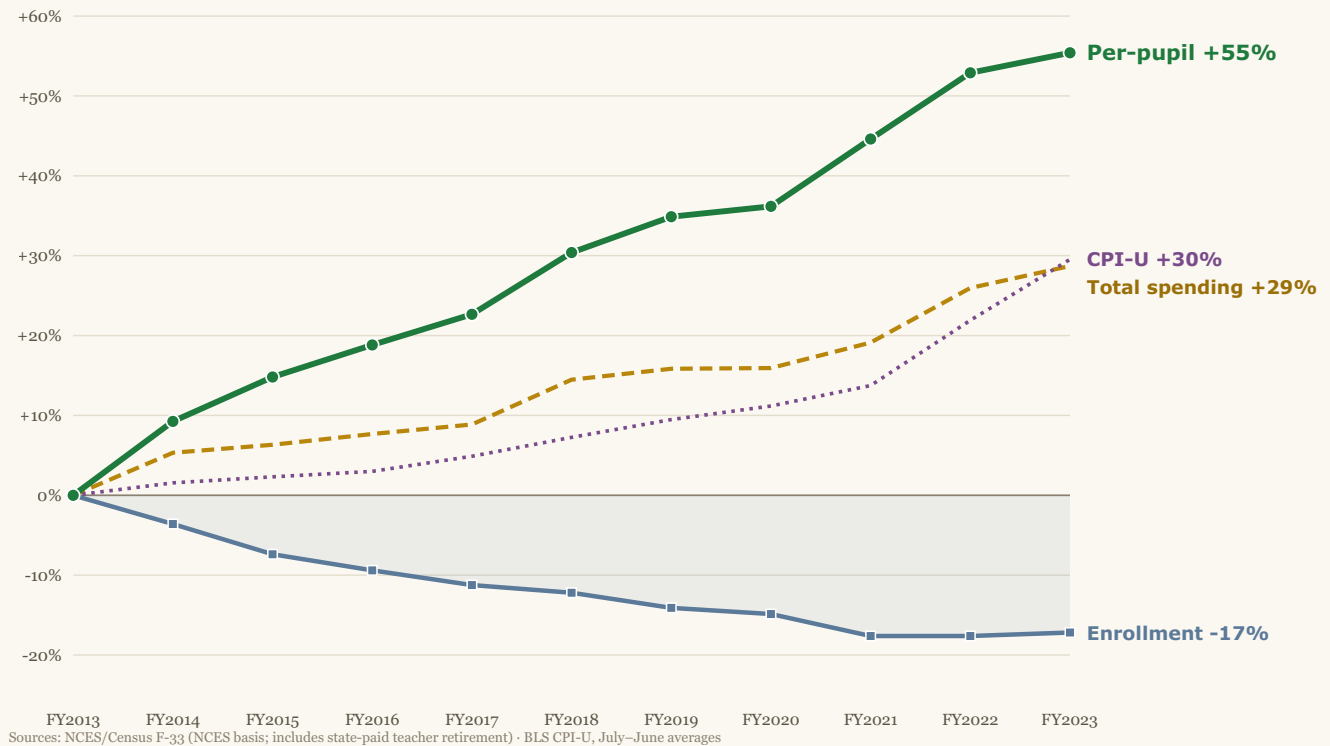
Block 1: the core region and its bordering towns



The pattern softens but does not change. Combined spending grew 28.7 percent, still slightly below inflation: the entire contiguous eleven-district region cost marginally less in real dollars in 2022-23 than a decade earlier. Enrollment fell 17 percent. Per-pupil cost rose 55 percent.

Block 1: the core region and its bordering towns

Cumulative change since FY2013: per-pupil cost, total current spending, enrollment, and inflation



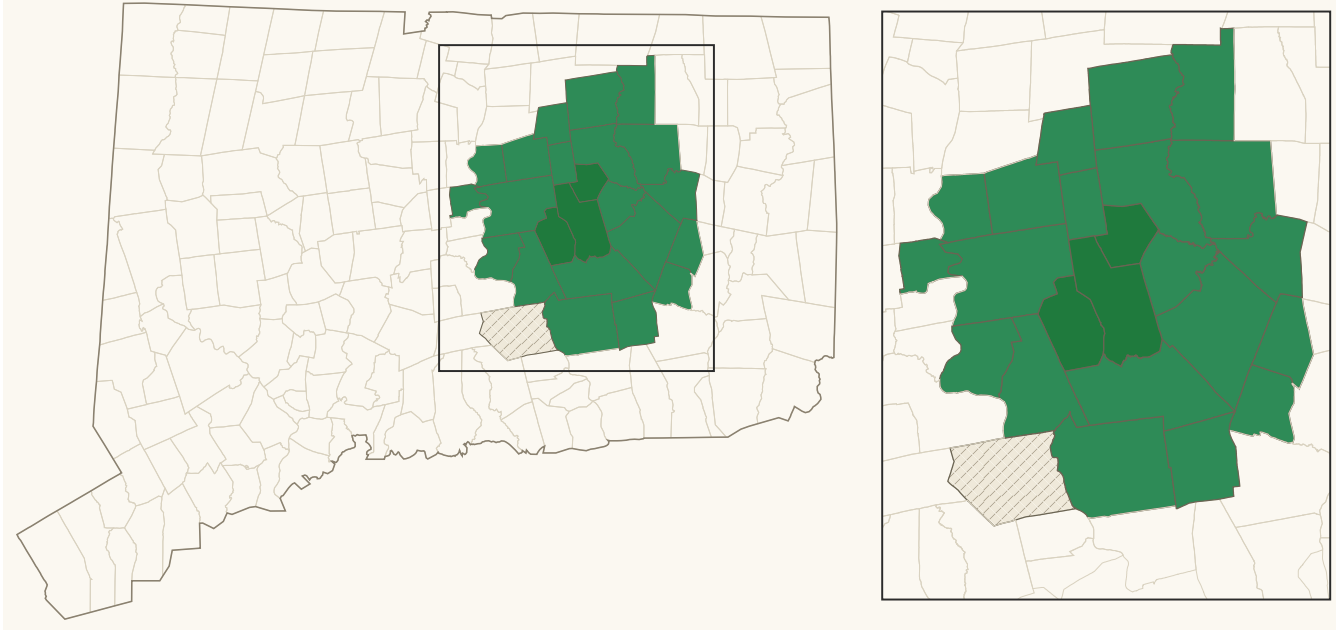
Block 1, FY 2013 – FY 2023 ✓ *Computed from NCES/Census F-33*

Fiscal year	School year	Students	Total current spending	Per pupil
2013	2012-13	19,363	\$297,342,000	\$15,356
2014	2013-14	18,665	\$313,153,000	\$16,778
2015	2014-15	17,932	\$316,136,000	\$17,630
2016	2015-16	17,544	\$320,129,000	\$18,247
2017	2016-17	17,186	\$323,693,000	\$18,835
2018	2017-18	17,001	\$340,400,000	\$20,022
2019	2018-19	16,632	\$344,465,000	\$20,711
2020	2019-20	16,484	\$344,697,000	\$20,911
2021	2020-21	15,951	\$354,186,000	\$22,205
2022	2021-22	15,950	\$374,495,000	\$23,479
2023	2022-23	16,036	\$382,689,000	\$23,864

Notes: NCES/Census F-33 school district finance data, NCES basis (current elementary-secondary expenditure; includes state on-behalf teacher retirement). Enrollment is F-33 fall membership (October counts). FY2022-23 harmonized from Census unit files; verified to reconcile exactly with the NCES series on the FY2021 overlap. Per pupil is combined spending divided by combined students, which weights each district by its enrollment.

Part 7 — Block 2: One Ring Further

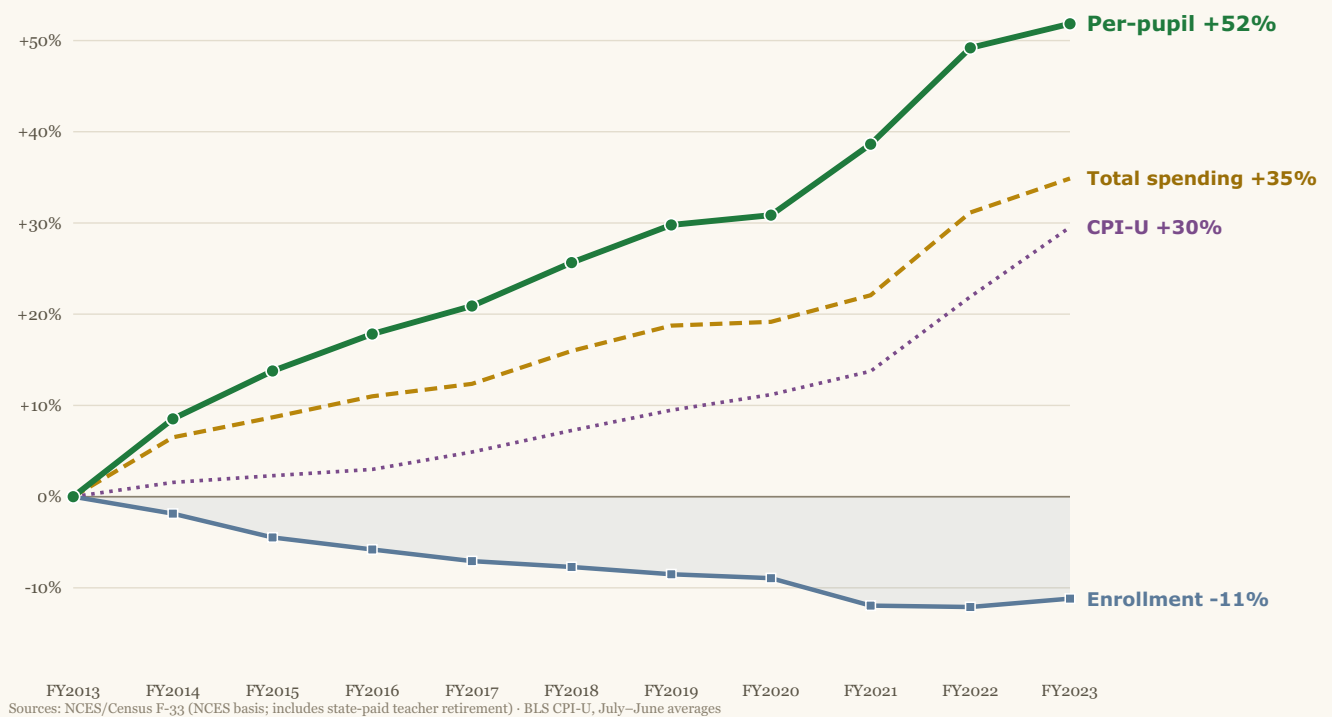
Block 2: through the second contiguity ring



Block 2 extends to every town bordering block 1, twenty-four districts enrolling about 45,000 students. Spending growth (34.9 percent) now edges above inflation and the enrollment decline moderates to 11 percent. The per-pupil line, at 52 percent, barely moves: across every widening of the lens, per-pupil growth stays in a narrow band while its composition shifts from enrollment loss toward spending growth.

Block 2: through the second contiguity ring

Cumulative change since FY2013: per-pupil cost, total current spending, enrollment, and inflation



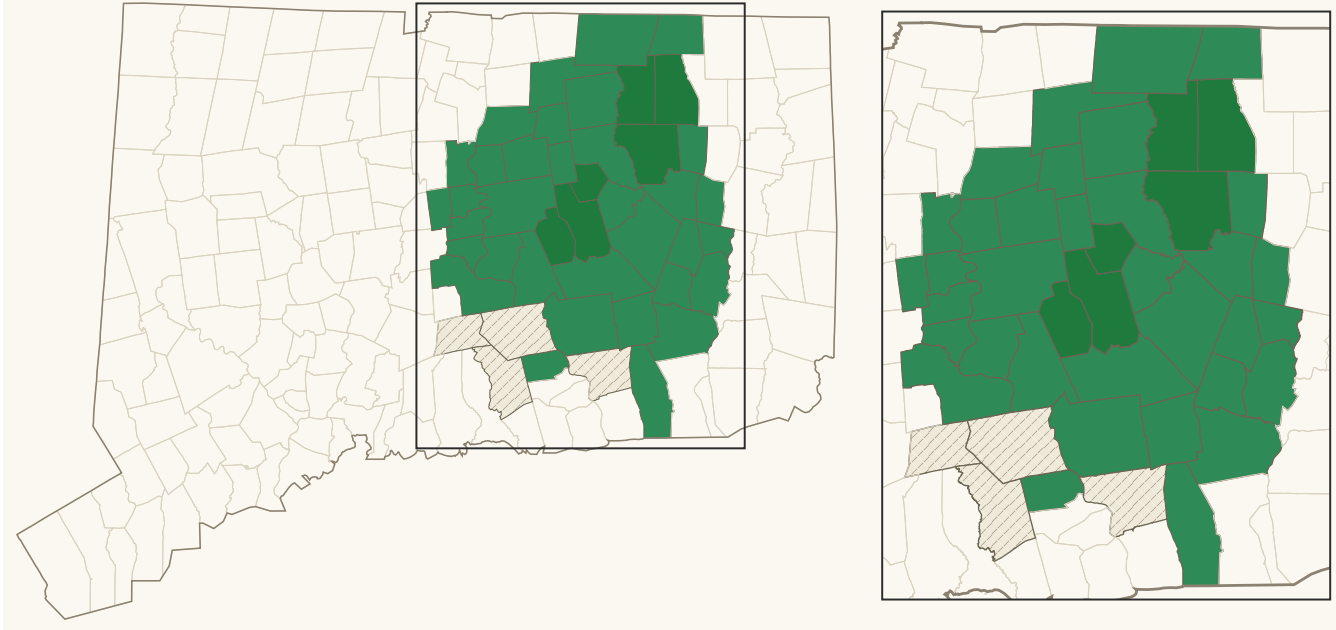
Block 2, FY 2013 – FY 2023 ✓ *Computed from NCES/Census F-33*

Fiscal year	School year	Students	Total current spending	Per pupil
2013	2012-13	51,056	\$821,856,000	\$16,097
2014	2013-14	50,105	\$875,274,000	\$17,469
2015	2014-15	48,777	\$893,299,000	\$18,314
2016	2015-16	48,099	\$912,254,000	\$18,966
2017	2016-17	47,449	\$923,426,000	\$19,461
2018	2017-18	47,120	\$953,055,000	\$20,226
2019	2018-19	46,713	\$975,917,000	\$20,892
2020	2019-20	46,493	\$979,316,000	\$21,064
2021	2020-21	44,958	\$1,003,261,000	\$22,316
2022	2021-22	44,877	\$1,077,819,000	\$24,017
2023	2022-23	45,353	\$1,108,512,000	\$24,442

Notes: NCES/Census F-33 school district finance data, NCES basis (current elementary-secondary expenditure; includes state on-behalf teacher retirement). Enrollment is F-33 fall membership (October counts). FY2022-23 harmonized from Census unit files; verified to reconcile exactly with the NCES series on the FY2021 overlap. Per pupil is combined spending divided by combined students, which weights each district by its enrollment. Excluded from the aggregate: Haddam (no local district; member of Region 17 (Haddam-Killingworth)).

Part 8 — Block 3: The Wider Region

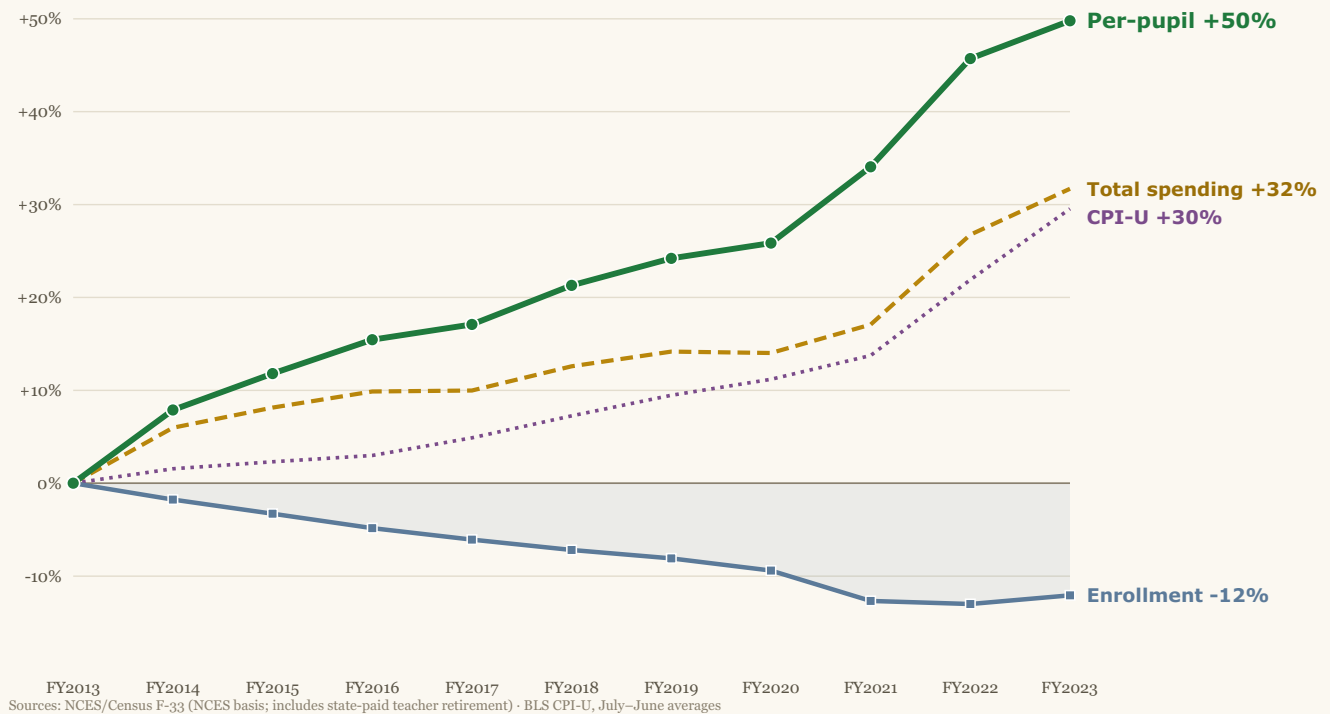
Block 3: through the third contiguity ring



Block 3 reaches roughly 96,000 students across forty-three districts, including two more regional districts (17 and 19) whose member towns fall entirely inside the block. The figures are now close to the statewide pattern: spending up 31.7 percent, enrollment down 12.1 percent, per-pupil up 49.8 percent.

Block 3: through the third contiguity ring

Cumulative change since FY2013: per-pupil cost, total current spending, enrollment, and inflation



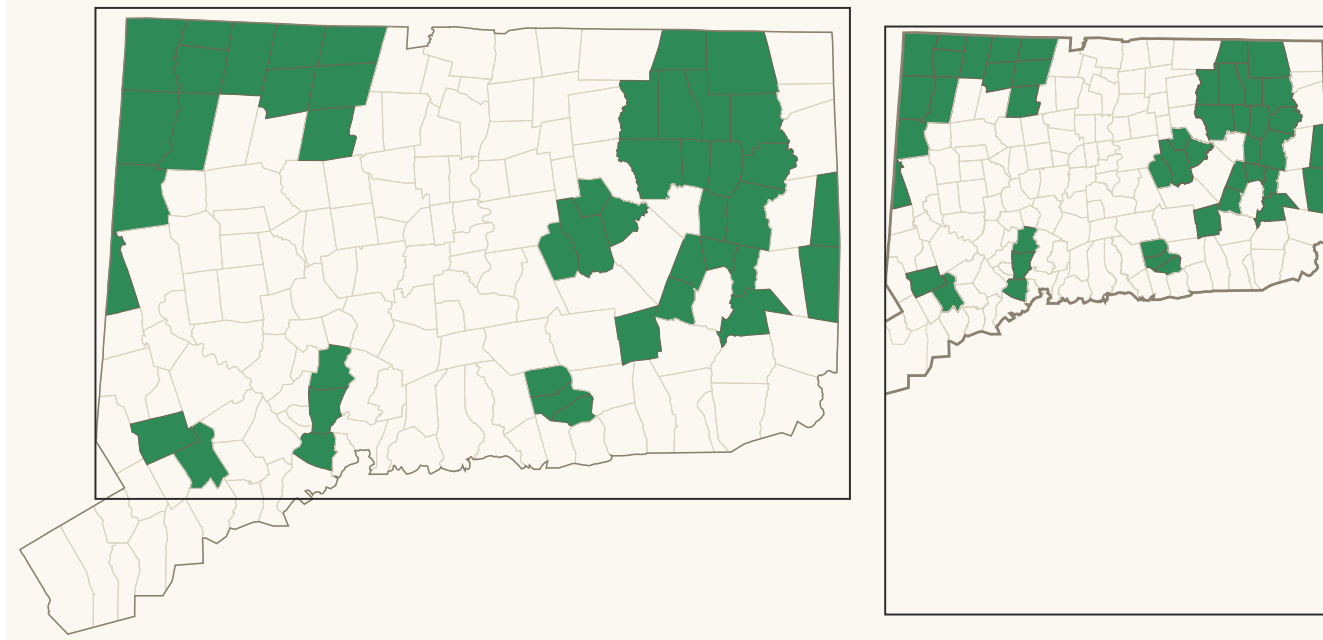
Block 3, FY 2013 – FY 2023 ✓ *Computed from NCES/Census F-33*

Fiscal year	School year	Students	Total current spending	Per pupil
2013	2012-13	109,093	\$1,810,086,000	\$16,592
2014	2013-14	107,169	\$1,918,291,000	\$17,900
2015	2014-15	105,512	\$1,957,397,000	\$18,551
2016	2015-16	103,818	\$1,988,823,000	\$19,157
2017	2016-17	102,462	\$1,990,713,000	\$19,429
2018	2017-18	101,254	\$2,037,840,000	\$20,126
2019	2018-19	100,267	\$2,066,505,000	\$20,610
2020	2019-20	98,840	\$2,063,893,000	\$20,881
2021	2020-21	95,268	\$2,119,183,000	\$22,244
2022	2021-22	94,901	\$2,294,380,000	\$24,177
2023	2022-23	95,921	\$2,383,959,000	\$24,853

Notes: NCES/Census F-33 school district finance data, NCES basis (current elementary-secondary expenditure; includes state on-behalf teacher retirement). Enrollment is F-33 fall membership (October counts). FY2022-23 harmonized from Census unit files; verified to reconcile exactly with the NCES series on the FY2021 overlap. Per pupil is combined spending divided by combined students, which weights each district by its enrollment. Excluded from the aggregate: Durham (no local district; member of Region 13 (Durham-Middlefield)); Haddam (no local district; member of Region 17 (Haddam-Killingworth)); Killingworth (no local district; member of Region 17 (Haddam-Killingworth)); Lyme (no local district; member of Region 18 (Lyme-Old Lyme)).

Part 9 — The 45 Elementary-Only Peers

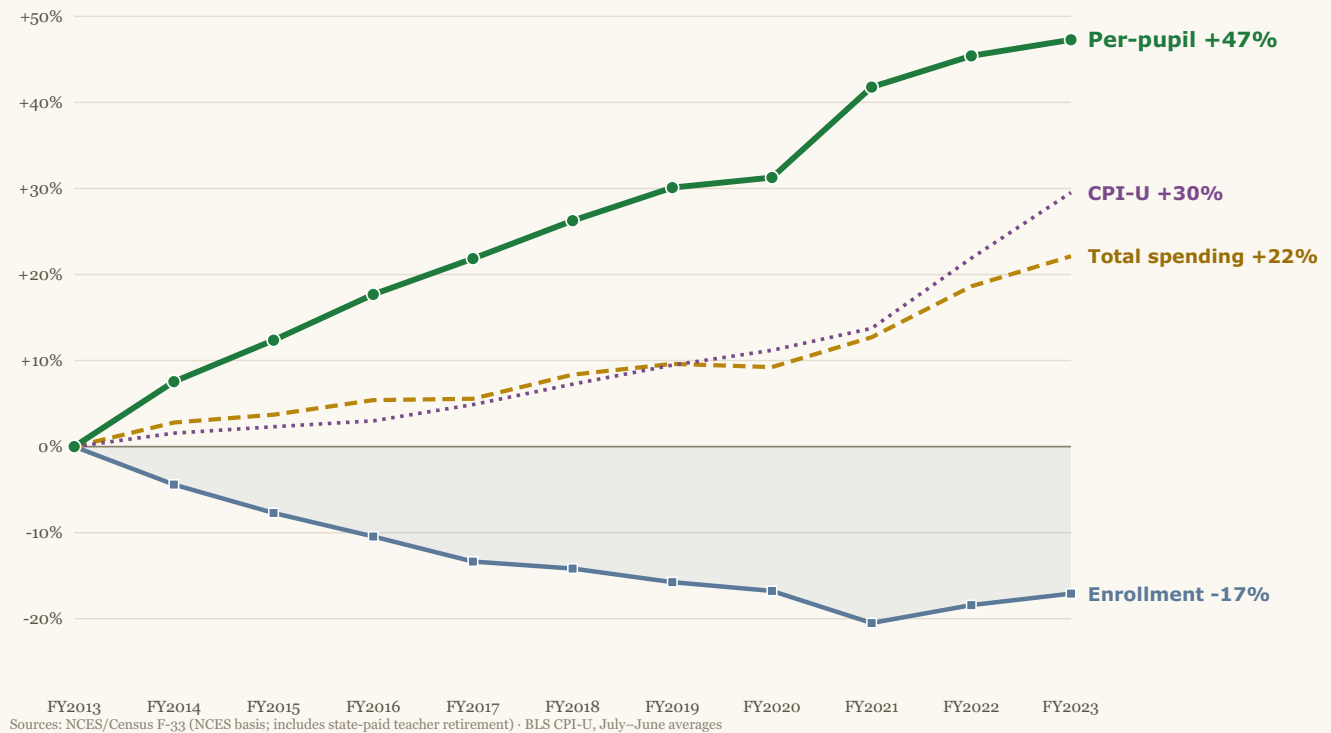
The 45 elementary-only peer districts



Andover, Hebron, and Marlborough belong to a structural peer group: the 45 Connecticut districts that, like them, operate elementary schools only and send their older students to regional or receiving districts. These are overwhelmingly small towns, concentrated in the state's northwest and northeast corners. As a group they look like a milder version of the core: spending up 22.1 percent (seven points below inflation), enrollment down 17.1 percent, per-pupil up 47.3 percent. Real spending restraint amid enrollment decline is not a local anomaly; it is the normal condition of Connecticut's small elementary districts.

The 45 elementary-only peer districts

Cumulative change since FY2013: per-pupil cost, total current spending, enrollment, and inflation



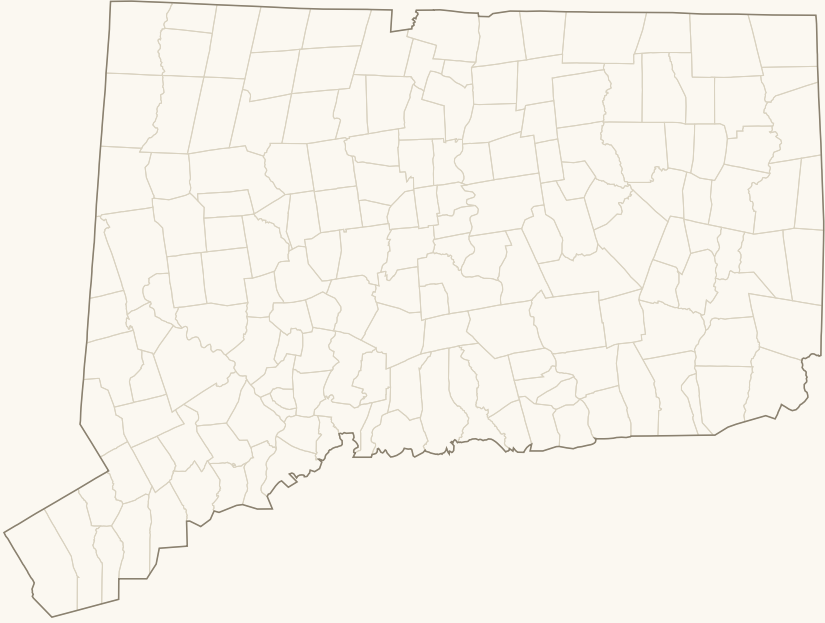
The 45 peers, FY 2013 – FY 2023 ✓ *Computed from NCES/Census F-33*

Fiscal year	School year	Students	Total current spending	Per pupil
2013	2012-13	20,383	\$361,781,000	\$17,749
2014	2013-14	19,484	\$371,918,000	\$19,088
2015	2014-15	18,811	\$375,178,000	\$19,945
2016	2015-16	18,255	\$381,293,000	\$20,887
2017	2016-17	17,659	\$381,903,000	\$21,627
2018	2017-18	17,494	\$392,025,000	\$22,409
2019	2018-19	17,173	\$396,534,000	\$23,091
2020	2019-20	16,963	\$395,203,000	\$23,298
2021	2020-21	16,203	\$407,723,000	\$25,163
2022	2021-22	16,628	\$429,166,000	\$25,810
2023	2022-23	16,902	\$441,849,000	\$26,142

Notes: NCES/Census F-33 school district finance data, NCES basis (current elementary-secondary expenditure; includes state on-behalf teacher retirement). Enrollment is F-33 fall membership (October counts). FY2022-23 harmonized from Census unit files; verified to reconcile exactly with the NCES series on the FY2021 overlap. Per pupil is combined spending divided by combined students, which weights each district by its enrollment.

Part 10 — Connecticut Statewide

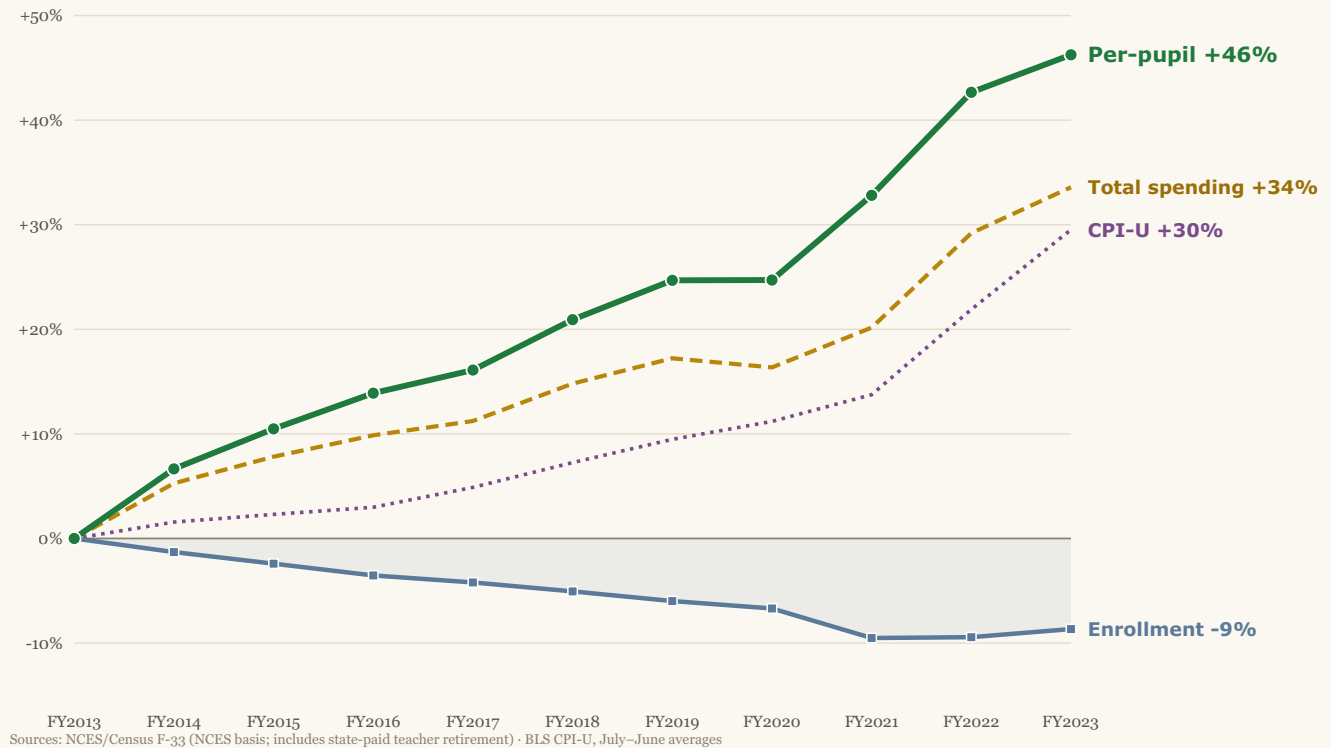
Connecticut statewide



The state as a whole, held to a constant universe of 174 traditional local and regional districts, closes the sequence. Spending grew 33.6 percent, about four points above inflation. Enrollment fell 8.7 percent. Per-pupil cost rose 46.3 percent, meaning that even statewide, roughly a third of the decade's per-pupil growth is the shrinking denominator rather than new spending. And the timing matters: essentially all of the state's real spending growth occurred before FY 2019; from FY 2019 through FY 2023, the spending and inflation lines rise in near lockstep.

Connecticut statewide

Cumulative change since FY2013: per-pupil cost, total current spending, enrollment, and inflation



Connecticut statewide, FY 2013 – FY 2023 ✓ Computed from NCES/Census F-33

Fiscal year	School year	Students	Total current spending	Per pupil
2013	2012-13	517,812	\$8,529,875,000	\$16,473
2014	2013-14	511,082	\$8,979,397,000	\$17,569
2015	2014-15	505,366	\$9,197,103,000	\$18,199
2016	2015-16	499,494	\$9,371,901,000	\$18,763
2017	2016-17	496,074	\$9,487,857,000	\$19,126
2018	2017-18	491,590	\$9,792,860,000	\$19,921
2019	2018-19	486,809	\$9,999,141,000	\$20,540
2020	2019-20	483,151	\$9,925,529,000	\$20,543
2021	2020-21	468,502	\$10,249,922,000	\$21,878
2022	2021-22	468,926	\$11,020,709,000	\$23,502
2023	2022-23	472,943	\$11,394,627,000	\$24,093

Notes: NCES/Census F-33 school district finance data, NCES basis (current elementary-secondary expenditure; includes state on-behalf teacher retirement). Enrollment is F-33 fall membership (October counts). FY2022-23 harmonized from Census unit files; verified to reconcile exactly with the NCES series on the FY2021 overlap. Per pupil is combined spending divided by combined students, which weights each district by its enrollment.

Summary Table

Group	Per-pupil	Total spending	Enrollment	Spending vs. inflation (+29.5%)
Andover	+68.5%	+5.7%	-37.3%	24 points below
Hebron	+40.0%	+4.1%	-25.6%	25 points below
Marlborough	+67.8%	+19.7%	-28.6%	10 points below
RHAM	+84.8%	+26.2%	-31.7%	3 points below
The four combined	+67.7%	+17.2%	-30.1%	12 points below
Block 1	+55.4%	+28.7%	-17.2%	1 point below
Block 2	+51.8%	+34.9%	-11.2%	5 points above
Block 3	+49.8%	+31.7%	-12.1%	2 points above
The 45 peers	+47.3%	+22.1%	-17.1%	7 points below
Connecticut statewide	+46.3%	+33.6%	-8.7%	4 points above

Notes: All figures are cumulative change, FY 2013 to FY 2023, on the NCES F-33 basis described in the methodology. CPI-U rose 29.5 percent over the same window on July-to-June fiscal-year averages.

TAKEAWAYS

Key Observations

The region's schools cost less, in real dollars, than they did a decade ago. Combined spending for Andover, Hebron, Marlborough, and RHAM grew 17 percent over ten years while prices rose 29.5 percent. Every one of the four districts, taken separately, also grew more slowly than inflation.

Rising per-pupil cost here is an enrollment story, not a spending story. The four districts lost 30 percent of their students. A ratio whose numerator shrank in real terms and whose denominator shrank far faster will rise; that is arithmetic, not extravagance.

The pattern weakens smoothly with distance. Each widening of the lens, from the core through three contiguous blocks to the state, trades enrollment decline for spending growth while per-pupil growth stays inside a narrow band, from 46 to 68 percent. The core towns are the extreme of a statewide gradient, not an exception to it.

Even statewide, the denominator does real work. Connecticut's per-pupil cost rose 46 percent while spending rose 34 percent; the difference is an 8.7 percent enrollment decline. And the state's real spending growth is concentrated before FY 2019; since then, spending has tracked inflation almost exactly.

Recent nominal jumps mostly reflect the inflation burst. The largest single-year spending increases in every group occur in FY 2022 and FY 2023, the same years CPI-U rose fastest. Nominal budget growth in those years is not evidence of accelerating real cost.

Small-district structure amplifies everything. The 45 elementary-only peers, as a group, show the same real restraint and deep enrollment loss as the core towns. Districts too small to shed fixed costs smoothly will always show the sharpest per-pupil arithmetic when students leave.

Enrollment has stopped falling, for now. All three towns and the combined region bottomed around FY 2021 and ticked up through FY 2023. RHAM, whose students arrive six years behind the elementary cohorts, likely has further decline ahead before any recovery reaches it.

CAVEATS

What This Report Does Not Show

This report describes trends in one consistent federal data series. It does not answer several adjacent questions, and readers should not stretch it to cover them. It says nothing about educational quality or outcomes in any district. It does not explain why enrollment fell; that is a demographic question involving birth rates, housing, and migration, not a school-policy one. It excludes capital projects and debt service, which the F-33 tracks separately from current spending. Its dollar levels are not comparable to NCEP or to town appropriations, because the federal basis includes state-paid retirement contributions and other costs that never pass through a local budget. Federal pandemic relief (ESSER) is included in the spending of FY 2021 through FY 2023, so a portion of those years' growth is one-time federal money rather than local burden. Fall membership counts include preschool where districts enroll it, and changes in preschool programs can move a small district's denominator at the margins, though the enrollment declines shown here are far too large to be preschool artifacts. Finally, the most recent federal data is FY 2023; the two budget years since, including the referendums of 2025 and 2026, are outside its window.

Sources

Federal school finance data

- U.S. Census Bureau and National Center for Education Statistics, School District Finance Survey (F-33): district-level series retrieved via the [Urban Institute Education Data Portal](https://educationdata.urban.org/) (https://educationdata.urban.org/) (FY 1992 – FY 2021) and from the Census Bureau’s [Annual Survey of School System Finances](https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/school-finances.html) (https://www.census.gov/programs-surveys/school-finances.html) individual unit files (FY 2021 – FY 2023), harmonized to the NCES basis and verified to reconcile exactly in the overlapping year.

Inflation

- U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Consumer Price Index for All Urban Consumers (CPI-U, not seasonally adjusted), monthly series averaged over July-to-June fiscal years; retrieved via [FRED](https://fred.stlouisfed.org/series/CPIAUCNS) (https://fred.stlouisfed.org/series/CPIAUCNS).

Geography

- U.S. Census Bureau, TIGER/Line 2023 county subdivision boundaries for Connecticut, used for town adjacency (land boundaries only, with mapped water bodies removed) and for all maps.

Data files

- [dataset.json](https://andoverct.info/reports/ahm/per-pupil-trends/dataset.json) (https://andoverct.info/reports/ahm/per-pupil-trends/dataset.json) — the canonical unit-level series and group definitions used by every chart, map, and table in this report
- [towns_xy.json](https://andoverct.info/reports/ahm/per-pupil-trends/towns_xy.json) (https://andoverct.info/reports/ahm/per-pupil-trends/towns_xy.json) — pre-projected town boundary geometry
- [cpi_fy.json](https://andoverct.info/reports/ahm/per-pupil-trends/cpi_fy.json) (https://andoverct.info/reports/ahm/per-pupil-trends/cpi_fy.json) — fiscal-year CPI-U averages

Other Formats

This report is available in three formats, all located alongside this page:



HTML

Interactive version with formatted tables and zoomable charts; best for on-screen reading and sharing.



Markdown

Plain-text version; readable in any editor, ideal for copying into other documents.



PDF

Print-ready version with all tables, charts, and source citations.